Will the EU open negotiating clusters 4 and 5 with Ukraine by 31 December 2026?

EU integration · confidence: medium · resolves YES if the Ukraine–EU intergovernmental conference formally opens both clusters: 4 “Green agenda and sustainable connectivity” and 5 “Resources, agriculture and cohesion”

TODAY · 8 NOV 2026 — EUROPEAN COUNCIL · DECEMBER — CHECK · 31 DEC 2026

25.07%

CONCLUSION

Opening both clusters by the end of the year is unlikely — 25.07%. Ukraine has already opened four of the six clusters, and the European Commission aims to open the rest by the end of 2026. The decisive condition is Hungary’s consent: without it clusters 4 and 5 will not open, and Hungary has three times refused to approve the preceding step — the screening results. The procedure can be completed in time only if consent comes in November: then the chance is 72.25%. Consent in the first half of December lowers it to 46.75%. If Hungary approves cluster 4 only, or nothing at all, the two clusters will not both open this year.

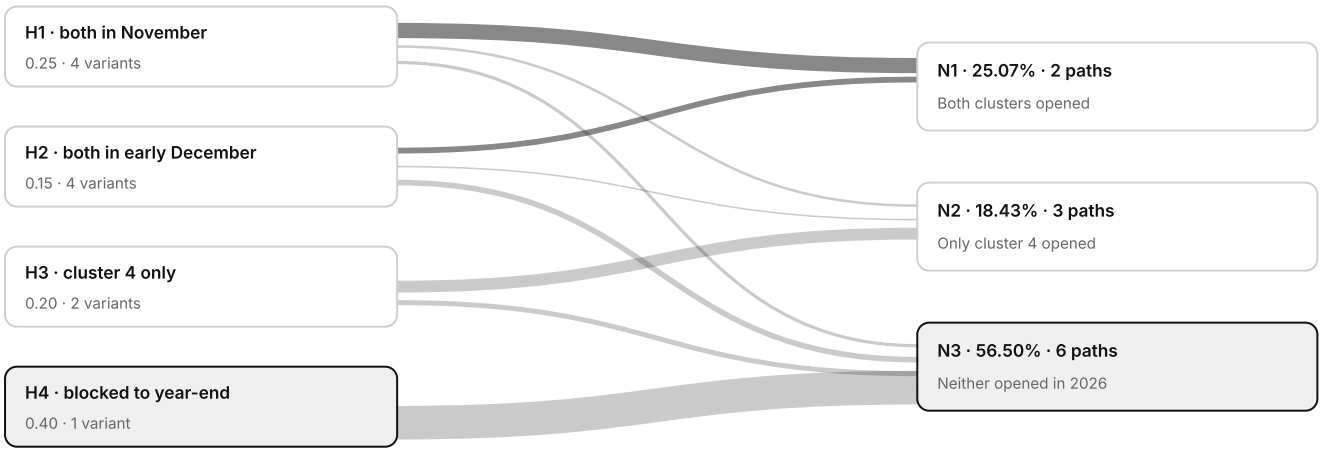
SCENARIOS · LEVEL 1 · CHANCE OF OPENING IN EACH

	P	BOTH
H1 · Hungary agrees to both in November	0.25	72.25%
H2 · agrees to both in early December	0.15	46.75%
H3 · agrees to cluster 4 only	0.20	0.00%
H4 · blocks both until year-end	0.40	0.00%

REVISION SIGNALS

- ▲ COELA approves screening for 4 and 5
- ▲ Ukraine invited to submit negotiating positions
- ▲ Zelensky–Magyar meeting ends in agreement
- ▼ another refusal without demands at COELA
- ▼ Polish objection to cluster 5
- ▼ no intergovernmental conference set by 20 Dec

Scenario flows



Analytical position

The analysis proceeds from **N3 — “neither cluster opened in 2026” (56.50%)**. This is the baseline, not an extreme outcome: all four scenarios lead to it, because even after Hungary agrees, the procedure may not finish by 31 December. The position changes if Hungary approves the screening at the next meeting of the Council working party: then the most likely outcome becomes **N1 — both clusters opened** (now 25.07%). The intermediate outcome **N2** (18.43%) — a staged opening, cluster 4 only — matches the Hungarian prime minister’s line of “not everything at once”.

COEFFICIENTS

Lvl	Variable	Coefficients	Why · research
1	Hungary's position on screening for clusters 4 and 5	0.25 · 0.15 · 0.20 · 0.40	Three refusals without demands; Ukraine's ambassador: Hungary is "asking for more time" rather than setting conditions. Magyar: open "not everything at once" → a separate scenario, H3. Member state–candidate disputes are the most persistent (ICDS 2025) → the largest weight goes to H4.
2	Will another state delay cluster 5	0.85 · 0.15	Cluster 5 is the least prepared — 24 points of alignment (Bruegel 2026); the CAP is the main budget burden, with farmer protests across Central and Eastern Europe (SWP 2026). But accession costs are spread into the 2040s (European Parliament 2025) → moderate risk.
3	Is the procedure in time by 31 Dec	0.85 · 0.55 · 0.70	For clusters 2–3, consent to the intergovernmental conference took 7 days (6 Oct → 13 Oct). Unanimity is also needed for the EU's positions (EPC 2025); the Irish presidency ends on 31 Dec → the later the consent, the lower the chance.

RESEARCH

Cluster 5: alignment with the acquis at 24 points against 75 in cluster 6; no progress in cluster 4 (Bruegel 2026)	level 2 · technical ground for delay
The CAP is the main burden; Ukraine adds ≈ ¼ of the EU's farmland (SWP 2026)	level 2 · cluster 5 is politically hardest
Accession costs €11.4–19.6 bn a year, with the full effect in the 2040s (European Parliament 2025)	level 2 · resistance is political, not budgetary
Member state–candidate disputes: the veto as leverage at every step (ICDS 2025)	level 1 · weight of H4
Unanimity at every step; qualified majority voting blocked by Hungary and Austria (EPC, ECFR 2025)	levels 1, 3 · no way around

SOURCES

Dabrowski, Louro. Progress made by EU candidate countries on accession-related reforms. Bruegel WP 16/2026	**A2**
Lippert, von Ondarza, Seebass. EU Enlargement: Ukraine as a Special Case. SWP Comment 17/2026	**A2**
Rubio, Alcidi, Begg et al. Adapting the EU budget… for future enlargements. European Parliament, BUDG, 2025	**A2**
Blockmans, Berisha. From Stalemate to Solution: Bilateral Disputes in Enlargement. ICDS, 2025	**B2**
Morina. Accelerate the accessions. ECFR, 2025 · Paul, Taran. Getting fit to open negotiating clusters. EPC, 2025	**B2**
Official: Government of Ukraine, 13.10.2026 (clusters 2–3, 17 chapters); European Commission, STATEMENT/26/2181, 16.10.2026	**A1**

ALL VARIANTS

H1 → No other state objects to cluster 5 → Procedure in time (positions + IGC)	18.06%	**N1**
H1 → No other state objects to cluster 5 → Not in time by 31 Dec	3.19%	**N3**
H1 → Another state delays cluster 5 (agriculture) → Procedure in time (positions + IGC)	3.19%	**N2**
H1 → Another state delays cluster 5 (agriculture) → Not in time by 31 Dec	0.56%	**N3**
H2 → No other state objects to cluster 5 → Procedure in time (positions + IGC)	7.01%	**N1**
H2 → No other state objects to cluster 5 → Not in time by 31 Dec	5.74%	**N3**
H2 → Another state delays cluster 5 (agriculture) → Procedure in time (positions + IGC)	1.24%	**N2**
H2 → Another state delays cluster 5 (agriculture) → Not in time by 31 Dec	1.01%	**N3**
H3 → Procedure in time (positions + IGC)	14.00%	**N2**
H3 → Not in time by 31 Dec	6.00%	**N3**
H4	40.00%	**N3**

WHAT CHANGES THE ESTIMATE

Consent to both in November	**72.25%**
Consent in the first half of December	**46.75%**
Consent to cluster 4 only	0% both · 70% cluster 4
Block until year-end	0%

Limitations: data on Hungary's position come from diplomatic reports (C3); COELA minutes are not published. A base rate for "a veto lifted within two months" has not been calculated.

Next review: after the next COELA meeting. The brief estimates only the probability of a procedural event.